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WHAT ASEMIC WRITING IS, AND WHY

Asemic writing existed long before there was a name for it. It was given that name by two visual poets, Tim Gaze and Jim Leftwich, who adopted a term that had already been used, on occasion, to describe certain aspects of language. *Asemic* appears (in French as well as in translation) in Roland Barthes's *The Rustle of Language* and in Jacques Derrida's *Dissemination*. Barthes applies the term to a word produced by a typographical mistake—for instance, *offiver* instead of *officer* (323). The result is a “pure signifier” that, free of any preordained signification, is released into “efflorescence.” Derrida describes the “supplementary mark of the blank” between words as “asemic spacing” (258); it makes signification possible, without in itself signifying. Gaze and Leftwich, however, seem to have gravitated to this word quite independently, for reasons that Leftwich explains in a letter to Gaze written on January 27, 1998:

A seme is a unit of meaning, or the smallest unit of meaning (also known as a sememe, analogous with phoneme). An asemic text, then, might be involved with units of language for reasons other than that of producing meaning. As such, the asemic text would seem to be an ideal, an impossibility, but possibly worth pursuing for just that reason. (*Asemic Writing* 3)

When the linguistic term *seme* (derived from the Greek *sema*, “sign”) is preceded by the privative *a-*, the normal meaning of what follows is negated or neutralized (compare *moral* and *amoral*). In the case of *asemic* it is meaning itself, or rather the sign's capacity to convey meaning, that is eliminated. So asemic writing is writing that does not attempt to communicate any message other than its own nature as writing. It is, in the words of Michael Jacobson,

“a shadow, impression, and abstraction of conventional writing” (“On Asemic Writing”). This distinguishes it from nonsense or gobbledygook or whatever may be produced by those emblematic monkeys whaling away at typewriters. In all of those cases we have before our eyes, if not a coherent message, at least a coherent sign system. We can recognize the letters on the page as signs that we are familiar with, even if they are not employed to form known words for communicative purposes. Asemic writing removes even this minimal reassurance. The signs before our eyes don’t belong to any familiar system. At the same time, they put themselves forward in the form of a sign system, recognizable as marks disposed on a page according to certain conventions. Those marks often hint at systems that are more comprehensible, such as Chinese characters, Islamic calligraphy, or Paleolithic pictographs. At its simplest, asemic writing is, according to Gaze, “anything which looks like writing, but in which the person viewing can’t read any words” (*Asemic Movement 1*). By this definition terrible handwriting would qualify, and indeed Gaze would go along with this. Even if it is not intended as a piece of asemic writing, an illegible scrawl may produce an asemic effect in viewers, replacing the expected message with an unexpected focus on the material configurations of the markings on the page.¹ Faced with signs that encourage us to read them at the same time that they systematically frustrate our reading, we may find ourselves replicating what psychiatry calls *asemia*—a condition in which the patient is unable to use or understand communicative symbols.

Gaze and Leftwich coined the term *asemic* because, suddenly, there was a need for it. Near the end of the 1990s, hundreds of artists began to produce asemic writing, self-publishing and influencing each other through the Internet. What emerged from these alliances was not a general consensus, an artistic practice governed by conventions that might be as constraining as those that govern writing itself. Rather, uncoupled from its communicative function, asemic writing exploded into an exuberant variety. Merely paging through the illustrations in this book will give you some idea of that variety, and this can be supplemented by the torrent of images now on the web. The delirium of styles that is asemic writing is perhaps best captured by James Joyce in seven break-neck pages of *Finnegans Wake* cataloging the cacophonies of antique manuscripts, such as “those indignant whiplooplashes; those so prudently bolted or blocked rounds; the touching reminiscence of an incompletet trail or dropped

final; a round thousand whirligig glorioles, prefaced by (alas!) now illegible airy plume flights" (119). And yet: "it is not a miseffectual whyacinthinous riot of blots and blurs and bars and balls and hoops and wriggles and juxtaposed jottings linked by spurts of speed: it only looks as like it as damn it" (118). Asemic writing may look "miseffectual" because illegible; but it has effects that are different from those of conventional communicative writing. It is the aim of this book to explore that difference.

The timing of this liberatory movement is significant, for it comes at a point of crisis for writing, understood as material and handwritten. Writing today is almost invariably done by keyboarding rather than by an instrument moving across a blank paper surface. That familiar act was always perhaps more strange than we took the time to realize; and now it has once again become alien to many. The decline of cursive writing in the West is a fact. New national teaching standards adopted by forty-six U.S. states require proficiency in computer keyboarding by the fourth grade; however, cursive writing ability is not mentioned and is no longer a requirement. Even when teachers take up the option to teach cursive, a generation for whom keyboarding has become second nature is unlikely to adopt it. One index of the state of things is the SAT, the standardized test that thousands of U.S. high school seniors take every year. In 2005 the administering board for the test mandated a handwritten essay; a check in 2007 showed that 85 percent of high school students printed their essays (Breens). My bank manager says that most of her younger clients print their signatures on mortgage and loan applications, and that this is now acceptable.

The decline of cursive was brought into prominence for many during the 2013 trial of George Zimmerman for the shooting of Trayvon Martin. Witness Rachel Jeantel, a black nineteen-year-old friend of Martin, was asked to read aloud a letter that she had dictated to a friend, in which she described to Martin's parents what she heard while on the phone with him. When she said she could not read the letter, the defense attorney asked her, "Are you able to read at all?" "Some but not all," she responded. "I don't read cursive." This "cringe-worthy moment" added another controversy to the already controversial trial, as Jeantel was subjected to a trial of her own.² How could a high school student be so illiterate? But of course an inability to read cursive is not the same thing as illiteracy—this is to blur the very distinction that Jeantel herself had

made. Moreover, Jeantel was hardly an exception among those in her age group. For them, cursive writing is already in effect asemic.

Of course there is pushback, arising out of concern that we are raising a generation of handwriting illiterates. If we can no longer read handwriting, critics object, how will students be able to read historical documents like the Declaration of Independence?—to which it is not unfair to ask when you last read the Declaration of Independence in any form, let alone in its eighteenth-century script. More disturbing would be the inability to make out the writing of one's grandparents, in love letters or letters from the front. An inability to write cursive can also be a disadvantage in less obvious areas, like cake decorating. Beyond the purely practical, arguments are often made that the physicality of cursive letter formation creates an intimate bond between the writer and the words written; that cursive requires a greater attentiveness and therefore retention; and that it develops areas of the brain that would otherwise lie fallow (Konnikova). For such reasons, bills to make training in cursive a mandatory part of the school curriculum have been approved in North Carolina, California, Massachusetts, and Georgia. The physical skills of writing by hand may be disappearing, but they do not go gently, no matter how widespread other forms of writing may become. Indeed, for Roland Barthes such "other forms" do not really qualify as writing:

What constitutes writing, ultimately, is not the sign (analytic abstraction), but, much more paradoxically, *the cursivity of the discontinuous* (what is repeated is necessarily discontinuous). Make a loop: you produce a sign; but shift it forward, your hand still resting there on the receptive surface; you generate a writing: writing is the hand which bears down and advances or hangs back, *always in the same direction*. ("Réquichot" 219)

The forward impetus in writing that Barthes emphasizes here reflects a progressive unfolding of the writer's thought; it also produces and defines that thought. Now, however, familiar forms of thought are thrown into question as the material forms of writing that embodied them are abandoned. To think through the broader consequences of this change is the task taken on by the self-described "communicologist" Vilém Flusser.

Flusser's consideration of writing—and not just cursive writing—is most fully carried out in his book *Does Writing Have a Future?* The answer to the question that his title poses is no: writing does not have a future. For Flusser, a self-confessed writing addict, this is not a cause for rejoicing. “There are people,” he says, “and I count myself among them, who believe that they could not live without writing” (3). To be sure, “writing will persist, like a useless appendix” (122), because it is an ingrained habit. However, it is no longer an essential component of the future. Rather, the future is a matter of moving “into the universe of technical images,” to use the title of a companion book by Flusser. He is not alone in identifying this pivotal moment. André Leroi-Gourhan asserts that “writing is probably doomed to disappear rapidly” and that this is a new “liberation” (404). Brian Rotman similarly asserts that “the *regime* of the alphabet . . . appears to be drawing to a close” (4). So, according to Flusser, writing has now begun to take on a certain strangeness: “This is the way lines of letters look in their final stage: . . . torn rags of lines with gaping holes in between” (*Does Writing Have a Future?* 136). Such strangeness, he says, emerges whenever media that are being left behind are stripped of their covering of habit.

As it always happens with phenomena covered by habit and more than habit, writing becomes almost mysterious, if we discover it by deliberate consideration. If we draw off the cover of habit and more than habit, which renders writing an obvious gesture, taken at face value, it becomes a gesture of such complexity that it defies description. (“Gesture of Writing” 2)

To the degree that we have been immersed in cursive, it has been largely invisible to us by dint of its familiarity. We didn't really see writing, for with a few exceptions (calligraphy or really bad handwriting) we tended not to look at it but to look *through* it. It was rendered translucent, if not transparent, by the urge that propels any viewer of writing beyond the graphic fact to the concept that it is supposed to convey. Writing is considered a “transcription” of something else; and that something else is always more important than the writing itself, which serves as a mere secretary to an executive meaning. Only now, as we leave cursive behind, are we beginning to question what it was all along.

This is a textbook case of Marshall McLuhan's notion that "we look at the present through a rear-view mirror. We march backwards into the future" (73–74). Flusser's value is not that he prophesies the supplanting of books by computers, as others have done, but that he analyzes so perceptively the consequences of both the old and the new media. For Flusser, the shift away from writing has, most importantly, consequences for *thought*, for the ways in which we are programmed to think and what counts as thought.

The thought that precedes writing, Flusser observes, is very different from what it becomes on the page. The writing process begins when thoughts "begin to take a very nebulous shape within me" ("Gesture of Writing" 10). To write means to translate this nebulous and open-ended *shape* into a fixed *line*: "Writing is about setting ideas in lines, for unwritten ideas, left to their own devices, run in circles" (*Does Writing Have a Future?* 6). Only in a linear formulation is thought recognized as such; what precedes those lettered lines has generally been called by other, less prestigious names: rumination, free association, musing, reverie, and so forth. Now, contends Flusser, all of this is about to change with media—film, TV, computer screens—that are defined not by line but by surface.

The fact that writing is set out in lines has carried with it an implicit epistemology: "Lines represent the world by projecting it as a series of successions, in the form of a process. Western thought is 'historical' in the sense that it conceives the world in lines, therefore as process" ("Line and Surface" 21).³ That process is additive: the reader of a text follows a series of parts that culminate in a synthesis. A surface medium like painting reverses that process: the synthesis is present at first sight, and then the viewer traces analytically the various parts of the painting. Up until now, the textual notion of thought has been predominant:

For us, thinking was, and still is, a process that moves forward, that frees itself from images, from representations, that criticizes them, thereby becoming increasingly conceptual. We have the alphabet to thank for this understanding of thought and this understanding of thought to thank for the alphabet. (*Does Writing Have a Future?* 144–45)

Now, Flusser suggests, "it may be that what is happening at present is the attempt to incorporate linear thought into surface thought" ("Line and Surface"

29); an example would be film, with its narrative line incorporated into a series of moving images. But surface media can embody not only narrative lines but also concepts, the very concepts that have traditionally been the end product of a linear sequence:

In the future, the situation may become thus: Imaginal thought will be a translation from concept into image, and conceptual thought a translation from image to concept. . . . First there will be an image of something, then there will be an explanation of that image, and then there will be an image of that explanation. ("Line and Surface" 30)

This rather abstract futurology is exemplified in asemic writing. Traditional writing is already an image, even if we tend not to recognize it as such. To see it as marks on a surface, it is necessary to detach it from meaning. This is done by baffling any attempt to read the writing, that is, to follow its lines in the conventional way. Asemic writing replaces the familiar signs of the alphabet with its own enigmatic signs. Yet most asemic writing preserves the linear organization of conventional writing. The result is a kind of cognitive dissonance: writing is evoked at the same time that we are estranged from it. This strategy does not provide an "explanation" but rather something that *calls* for explanation—that is, a stimulus to thought. A bit further on in "Line and Surface" Flusser puts it like this:

Imaginal thought is becoming capable of thinking about concepts. It can transform a concept into its "object," and can therefore become a meta-thought of conceptual thinking. . . . Now, imaginal thought can begin thinking about concepts in the form of surface models. (30)

Asemic writing is an example of such surface models: it implicitly asks us to conceptualize what we are seeing—not reading. It frees us from the structuration of lines of thought, even as we see before us those very lines of thought. The markings we see represent thought processes but are without content. Severed from "instrumentality," as Barthes would call it, they owe allegiance to nothing other than their own contours and the abstract idea of writing that they evoke. Images, which before were something to be superseded by concepts in the accepted linear-verbal mode, now offer themselves for a very different purpose. Through imagination, Flusser claims, we are now able to objectify

concepts and thus free ourselves from them (“Line and Surface” 32). Foremost among such concepts must be the written materiality that has both expressed and defined the very idea of a “concept.” This, then, is an important aspect of the current phenomenon of asemic writing.

The link between Flusser’s ideas and asemic writing (which was not yet called that in his lifetime) is confirmed by his long relationship with Mira Schendel, an artist who shared many of his concerns and incorporated them into her work (Figure 1.1). Not all of that work is, strictly speaking, asemic, but in various ways it repeatedly questions our acceptance of textual modes of thinking. Schendel and Flusser met in São Paulo, Brazil, to which both had immigrated during the rise of Fascism in Europe. It was a stormy relationship, largely due to Schendel’s demanding intensity. Nevertheless, Flusser was very fond of her personally, respected the great artist in her, and valued their ongoing conversations. In a memoir about her, he writes:

Our dialogues affected Mira’s work (as they did mine, I hasten to add). And Mira’s work was the topic of the dialogue. That was the productive thing about our relationship: for Mira, I am a genuine critic: I influence her work. And she presents me with genuine issues that need to be thought and worked through. (“Mira Schendel” n.p.)

Schendel’s work often uses letters, as well as other signs, that float free of any linear arrangement. In the same memoir, Flusser describes one such work, given to him by the artist:

A sheet that hangs freely in space, suspended from the ceiling. It consists of two transparent sheets of acrylic about one and a half meters square, fastened together. Between the two sheets, very thin pieces of rice paper have been mounted in such a way that they overlap one another in places. The papers have been marked with black signs. Other signs have been inscribed on the four sides (the two inside, and two outside) of the acrylic sheets. Since it is all perfectly transparent, the observer is looking at a text through which he can see the room. And because the sheet swings easily with any air movement, the observer sees a text that changes constantly in space. . . . The text consists of at least four different kinds of signs: letters of type, letters of Latin script,

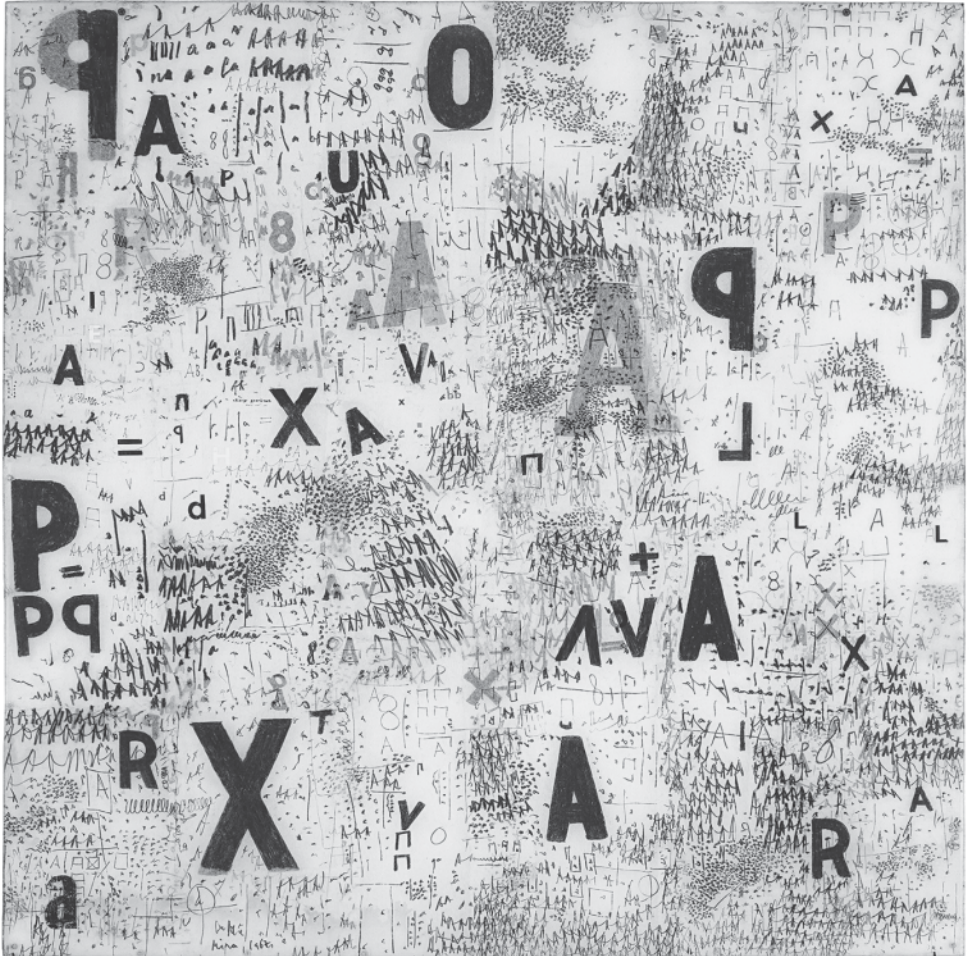


FIGURE 1.1. Mira Schendel (1919–1988; Brazil, born Switzerland), *Graphic Object*, 1967. Graphite, transfer type, and oil on paper between transparent acrylic sheets with transfer type. Museum of Modern Art, New York. Promised gift of Patricia Phelps de Cisneros through the Latin American and Caribbean Fund in honor of Luis Pérez-Orama. Copyright 2018 Estate of Mira Schendel. Courtesy Hauser & Wirth.

numbers and elements of calligraphic writing. [Many of these] yield words and sentences in various languages, giving the impression that one has somehow formed these words and sentences oneself. Others yield images of scenes, such as that of a swarm of bees consisting of “a,” or an army of “b’s” on the march. Still others yield geometric formations (spirals, for example). But all of these shapes call one another into question, because many can see through them and so reject them. The overall impression is one of a completely meaningless text, yet one that can be deciphered at any point if one focuses attention on just that point.

This is the asemic effect, suspending the observer in a productive tension. And what is produced, Flusser would assert, is conceptual: “We have before us an attempt to present thought constructions (‘concepts’) to us as images, to make them imaginable” (“Mira Schendel” n.p.).⁴

The fact that typefaces, recognizable letters of the alphabet, and even whole words are to be found in the piece Flusser describes (as well as many other works by Schendel) raises a reasonable question. If, conceptually, asemic writing marks a moment of rupture, then why don’t these artists choose to address print over handwriting? It is, after all, print that has dominated our culture for so many hundreds of years. Asemic artists have in fact addressed the familiar forms of print media: the Argentinian artist Mirtha Dermisache repeatedly made asemic versions of the daily newspaper, maintaining the layout, but substituting illegible characters (Figure 1.2). She also produced asemic versions of postcards, newsletters, short stories, and books: her first book, written in 1967, was five hundred pages long and contained not a single word. Such works illuminate the ways in which writing is tamed and contained by its socially accepted formats, a continuing preoccupation with Dermisache: “All my works,” she said, “create some tension between the communication formats offering a stable framework and the act of writing, which provides the unstable dimension” (“Artist’s Statement”). Other artists have designed asemic typefaces, and we will be examining the work of Xu Bing and Christopher Skinner as examples. But asemic art is usually based in handwriting, just as concrete poetry is based in print. One reason for this may be that while print is if anything produced more than before, handwriting, as we have seen, is in its last days. Distanced by disuse, handwriting becomes strange; it offers itself as a new subject for exploration, precisely because it has rather suddenly become old.



FIGURE 1.2. Mirtha Dermisache (1940–2012, Argentina), *Diario N° 1 Año 1*, 1972/1995. Offset print on paper, 47.5 × 36.6 cm (closed). Courtesy Archivo Mirtha Dermisache, Buenos Aires, 2018.

Another reason for asemic artists to be drawn to handwriting is because it is *drawn*. “What is the difference between writing the alphabet and drawing it?” asks the cartoonist Lynda Barry (36). No difference, Paul Klee would reply; writing and drawing, he said, are fundamentally the same (103). Fundamentally, yes—but distinctions can be made, and Tim Ingold lists four:

First, writing is a *notation*; drawing is not. Secondly, drawing is an *art*; writing is not. Thirdly, writing is a *technology*; drawing is not. Fourthly, writing is *linear*; drawing is not. None of these distinctions, as it turns out, is entirely trustworthy. . . . Writing is still drawing. But it is the special case of drawing in which *what is drawn comprises the elements of a notation*. (120–22)

It is worth noting that the presence of “the elements of a notation” does not require that these elements communicate anything whatsoever. The Voynich manuscript is a case in point: it has defied any attempt to retrieve from it an esoteric knowledge; yet it is recognizably a version of writing, albeit a cryptic one.

At a young age, children make no distinction between writing and drawing: a child will “write” you a chimney on top of her picture of a house, and will announce that she will “draw” her name (Dyson 372). Even before they are able to write their names, children will depict the look of a writing they cannot yet read. “Educators,” says Tim Gaze, “talk about children going through distinct stages of ‘mock letters,’ ‘pseudowriting’ and so on, when they’re learning to write. Many of us made asemic writing before we were able to write words” (*Asemic Movement 1*). Asemic works, then, may return us to our first childhood encounters with writing.

In an essay titled “All Writing Is Drawing,” the cartoonist and child psychologist Serge Tisseron argues that the equivalence asserted by Klee originates in a single graphic gesture found in a child’s earliest scribbles. As the child draws, the hand enacts a movement away from the axis of the body, a movement of loss. Looping back, though, the line lassos a section of space. This act of possession is confirmed as the eye registers the trace on the page—though the looping motion is performed too quickly for a conscious checking of the results, which comes at a later, more self-conscious stage. So “painting and writ-

ing,” Barthes said, “will have started with the same gesture, one which was neither figurative nor semantic but simply rhythmic” (Leeman 35). The result of this rhythmic process is the typical circularity of a child’s early scribbling. In *Tent Posts* Henri Michaux addresses such a child: “It pleased you to turn and to make things turn, and then repeat; without thought or study you dashed off spiraling lines that spawned endless whirlwinds: at an age to repeat, you took advantage of it right away, tirelessly circling, picking up again, again, starting over” (117). This repeated motion Tisseron relates to another famous repetition, that of the *fort-da* game played by Sigmund Freud’s grandson. As with that game, the aim of the graphic trace is to control the threat of loss, or rather to lasso something that, while writing is going on, still remains to be found. There is always the possibility that the blank page, which may be viewed as a site of infinite potential, may yet swallow up all the words we pour into it.

“Leaping into the void,” says Mary Jacobus, “the mark both creates space and defines it” (80); and this is part of a fascination with the graphic that begins in childhood and may be continued by adult writers and artists. Yet many a mark is returned to the void during writing’s ongoing revisions. In computer-generated text words disappear without a trace of the process that brought them into being. But when it is a hand that writes, the writing process is tumultuously evident in crossings-out, scrawled insertions, arrows, and (when all else fails) doodles. The chaos of the first draft, as genetic critics recognize, has its own eloquence, telling us something about the writer’s thought processes and psychology. This is so even when no word can be made out clearly, perhaps especially then. An illegible manuscript demands that one go beyond verbal information to the subtler messages conveyed by the way the marks on the page are drawn—matters of spacing, linear configurations, and overall texture.

For such reasons, the graphism of asemic writing can be linked to graphology. While graphology has generally been considered a somewhat dubious discipline, Walter Benjamin, for one, took it seriously. He was not only a theoretician but also a talented practitioner who was paid for his work and gave lessons. In two essays he took pains to detach graphology from its facile characterological aspects. Instead he viewed handwriting as a set of “hieroglyphs,” which is to say that he viewed writing as *image*. To the claim of one graphologist, Ludwig Klages, that “writing is determined by gesture,” Benjamin points out that “this

theory can be extended: gesture in its turn is determined by the inner image” (132), one that is fundamentally linked to the body. “Language has a body and the body has a language,” Benjamin writes; “graphology is concerned with the bodily aspect of the language of handwriting and with the expressive aspect of the body of handwriting” (133).⁵ It is perhaps only when language is drawn that the expressive sense of a body can fully emerge. While printed language can use various strategies to achieve expressive ends, what is expressed is something other than the body. In this sense, according to Brian Rotman, when language is spoken it says more than it does when it’s written:

We listen, it seems, not to speech sounds as such, not, that is, as isolatable sonic entities, but to the movements of the body causing them; we focus on what happens between the sounds, to the dynamics of their preparatory phrases, pauses, holds, accelerations, fallings away, and completions—the very features of gestures we attend [to] when we are perceiving them. (23)

In contrast to this gestural dimension of the voice,

alphabetic writing . . . splits the voice, selecting from the stream of speech (what it defines as) words to notate, jettisons all trace of their tone, and sets up its own neurological apparatus to handle the writing and reading of the resulting letter notations. (29)

So when it becomes writing, Rotman asserts, language loses the expressive aspect of the body. Certain prosodic strategies of literature—such as rhythm, verbal echoes, and the sculptural shape of sentences—work to restore the gestural component of speech, and with it an affect beyond articulation. But this affect can be produced instantaneously when the line on the page is itself an expressive gesture.

In sum, asemic writing has the potential to restore elements that are obliterated in the technology of the alphabet; and it can do this more effectively and eloquently than is the case with computer technology. For Flusser’s assertion that electronic media are impelling a fundamental shift toward “technical images” can be met with a counterargument: that alphabetic communication is not only more pervasive than ever but also more standardized; and this is due

precisely to the dominance of electronic media. Matthew Fuller and Andrew Goffey argue that “the policing of language that has historically been accomplished by specific norms of rationality and the institutions in which they are staged and advanced, is today accomplished more and more frequently by specific technological apparati” (149–50). Commenting on this sentence, Rita Raley lays out some of the characteristics of the new normal:

Character limits are a primary technique for the algorithmic management of language, limits from text field controls to messaging prodding the user to shape her language in accordance with presets, externally imposed constraints that operate according to logics of bureaucratic rationality. The elements of style now: more than a seemingly arbitrary number of characters would be unnecessary, excessive, unruly; and typographic symbols such as colons, semicolons, and dashes are decorative embellishments hindering the smooth functioning of plain text. The policing of form extends to design—optimal line lengths, article containers, templates, all “specific norms of rationality” enforcing consensus about linguistic and communicative standards, proper forms of expression that function under the alibi of “readability.” (n.p.)

The result is a global linguistic machine that offers templates not only for words but also for thought; that values information over affect; and that reinforces the long history of the alphabet’s dominance over Western thinking (De Looze).

To all this, asemic writing offers an implicit resistance. Moreover, it frequently expresses its aims under the same banner as that which it resists—a global language. Michael Jacobson, one of the leading spokespersons for asemic writing, lists among his goals “the creation of a transnational global post-literate writing culture” (Medsker). The Finnish artist Satu Kaikkonen amplifies:

Asemic art . . . represents a kind of language that’s universal and lodged deep within our unconscious minds. Regardless of language identity, each human’s initial attempts to create written language look very similar and, often, quite asemic. In this way, asemic art can serve as a sort of common language—albeit an abstract, post-literate one—that we can use to understand one another regardless of background or nationality. For all its limping-functionality, semantic language all too often divides

and asymmetrically empowers while asemic texts can't help but put people of all literacy-levels and identities on equal footing. (Kaikkonen and Melton)

Mirtha Dermisache puts it succinctly: of her work she says, "Anyone can read it as well as anyone" (Durgin). This comment, and Kaikkonen's "equal footing" may give a mistaken impression of unanimity—another version of the flattening out characteristic of that other global language, computer code. Asemic readers are equal, though, only in their freedom from prescribed modes of reading. They are free to meet the extraordinary variety of asemic writing with an equal variety of responses. Alongside his goal of a universal global language, Jakobson hopes for "a personal asemic language for everyone" (Medsker). That would mean, for both asemic writers and asemic readers, something exactly contrary to the unanimity of the "global": a new and beneficial Babel.

This tension between the personal and the global makes many asemic practitioners hesitate to see themselves as part of a "movement." Certainly there is a flood of asemic writing—it might even be described as a tsunami—to be found on the Internet and, increasingly, on the walls of art galleries. The term *asemic* has become widespread and is now being applied to work in film, sound art, dance, and even architecture. There is even a manifesto for "Asemic International," written by the Russian asemic artist Ekaterina Samigulina, that uses a familiar rhetoric ("Asemic workers of all countries, unite!") to encourage the use of asemic writing for political purposes. Such an agenda, and indeed the very idea of a codifying manifesto for asemic writing, has been generally opposed by its practitioners. Of course one can have a movement without having a manifesto, and the question then becomes how one defines a "movement." In 2015–16, the online journal SCRIPTjr.nl published a series in which twelve of the most prominent asemic artists were asked to respond to four specific questions about asemic writing; one of these questions asked whether asemic writing could be described as a movement. The responses were mixed. Christopher Skinner's answer is typical:

There is certainly a "community" of asemic artists out there, many of which are collaborating and promoting new works in a variety of formats. A movement would suggest that there is some underlying aim,

collective values and organized identity. My experience has been quite the opposite; many people doing their own thing, pleased that there are others with similar tastes and approaches, affording them the confidence to publish and promote their work together and solo.

Tim Gaze, in his response, is more at ease with asemic writing being called a movement. Indeed, he says, “I’m partly responsible, having published 3 issues of an e-zine titled *asemic movement*.” He then goes on to comment, “The movement is not just about examples of asemic writing; it also has potential to ask us to rethink some fundamental questions such as: *What is writing?* and *What is reading?*” It is those fundamental questions that have impelled this study.

Within the title of this introductory chapter, then, there can be found a shorter title with a larger scope: “What Writing Is, and Why.” This book will not fully answer that larger question—how could it?—but it will repeatedly engage with the question through the suggestive power of asemic art. What Flusser asserted of Mira Schendel’s work is true of work by every asemic artist: that it is “an attempt to present thought constructions to us as images, to make them imaginable.” This is not to say that asemic writing is the mere illustration of certain preexistent concepts. Rather, it is a provocation to thought; and the thinking it encourages is not that of a system or science. It is open-ended, based in wonder and in wondering. It has something to say about an abstract notion we call “writing”; but it reminds us that such a notion can exist only through a multitude of writings, each with its own individual expressivity. Consequently, the depiction of writing by asemic artists is endlessly varied. In forms of great beauty or power or strangeness, their works address themselves to the mind through the eye. The asemic, as its name indicates, may be without meaning; but it is not without significance.

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